



6 RECREATION & OPEN SPACE

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Kissimmee 2040 Comprehensive Plan

Recreation & Open Space

prepared for

City of Kissimmee

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date

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Cover photo source: City of Kissimmee Public Information Office

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GOALS, OBJECTIVES, AND POLICIES

This section stipulates goals, objectives, and implementing policies for the Recreation and Open Space Element pursuant to §163.3177(6) (e), Florida Statutes.

GOAL 6.1: PROVIDE ADEQUATE RECREATION AND OPEN SPACE.

Ensure provision of a comprehensive system of recreation facilities and open space sites that meet the needs of existing and projected user groups within the City.

OBJECTIVE 6.1.1: SYSTEM OF PARKS AND RECREATION.

The system of parks and recreation facilities shall continue to be improved and maintained over time in order to meet the needs of the existing and projected future population, including recreational and open space outside of the City of Kissimmee limits in unincorporated Osceola County but proximal to the City.

POLICY 6.1.1.1: LEVEL OF SERVICE STANDARDS FOR PARKS AND RECREATION FACILITIES.

The City of Kissimmee shall continue to maintain a minimum level of service standard of 5 acres per 1000 total residents. This standard shall be used as level of service criteria in reviewing proposals for development orders or permits. When possible, the City shall go beyond this standard and attain a higher level of service for its parks and recreation facilities.

POLICY 6.1.1.2: BALANCE OF PARK TYPES.

The City will continue to provide a balance of recreational facilities and parks to meet the recreational needs of its existing and future residents including neighborhood, community, regional, and special use park types, as well as large urban parks.

POLICY 6.1.1.3: DISTRIBUTION OF PARK TYPES.

The City shall continue to strive to locate new neighborhood, community, and special use parks and recreation facilities in areas and neighborhoods with the least access to existing parks and recreation facilities, in order to create an equitable distribution of parks throughout the City. Access to different park types shall be based on a comparison of the approximate travel distances on the transportation network anticipated for each park type to the maximum recommended travel distances for each park type. Recreational and open space areas should adjust with changing community preferences and may include passive and active uses such as urban plazas, place-making mini-parks, cultural facilities, and dog parks or skate parks.



POLICY 6.1.1.4: PLANNED CAPITAL IMPROVEMENTS TO MEET RECREATION FACILITY DEMANDS.

The Capital Improvements Element shall include scheduled funding for recreational facilities needed to meet deficiencies, and satisfy an equitable distribution of park types.

POLICY 6.1.1.5: RECREATION IMPACT FEES FOR RECREATION IMPROVEMENTS.

The City shall continue to enforce the mandatory recreation impact fee on all residential dwellings in order to ensure that new development provides for recreational demands generated by respective developments.

POLICY 6.1.1.6: FUTURE RECREATIONAL CAPITAL IMPROVEMENT.

If in the future the City identifies recreational improvements for which public funds are needed, as opposed to developer-financed improvements, the City shall schedule and incorporate such capital projects in the Capital Improvements Element.

POLICY 6.1.1.7: MAINTENANCE OF RECREATION LAND AND FACILITIES.

The City shall maintain existing and future recreational land and facilities through the City's general fund, recreation impact fees, and Capital Improvements budget for the materials, staffing, and equipment necessary to maintain those recreational lands. Recreational lands shall continue a regular schedule of maintenance by City employees to ensure that safety and aesthetic value is retained at all public parks, open space, and recreational facilities and properties throughout the City.

OBJECTIVE 6.1.2: PROTECT RECREATION FACILITIES AND PARKS.

The City shall continue to protect lands designated as recreation on the Future Land Use Map from incompatible land uses, and such designated lands shall remain functionally intact.

POLICY 6.1.2.1: PROTECTION FROM INCOMPATIBLE LAND USES.

The City shall continue to protect all lands designated "Recreation" on the Future Land Use Map from incompatible land uses by reviewing all development plans within a 300 foot radius from all public park and recreation facility properties. Signage will be placed designating "public park" at all properties designated as public parks, recreation facilities, and/or open space to ensure that these properties remain functionally intact.

POLICY 6.1.2.2: GRANTSMANSHIP FOR PASSIVE RECREATION FACILITY AND OPEN SPACE CONSERVATION.

The City of Kissimmee shall continue to pursue recreation and open space grant funds from available state and federal programs in order to implement recreation, open space, and



conservation goals, objectives, and policies maintaining in perpetuity a linear open space system for recreation along Shingle Creek.

POLICY 6.1.2.3: JOINT CITY - COUNTY SHINGLE CREEK CORRIDOR CONSERVATION AND RECREATION PROJECT.

The City shall continue to leverage funding and expand partnerships to enhance and maintain the Shingle Creek Regional Multiuse Trail and the Shingle Creek Regional Park which connect City and unincorporated County lands adjacent to environmentally fragile and scenic segments of Shingle Creek.

POLICY 6.1.2.4: OPEN SPACE IN DEVELOPMENTS WITH RESIDENTIAL USES.

The City shall continue to protect open space systems in single family and multi-family residential developments, and all mixed use projects with residential components outside of the Multimodal Transportation District by enforcing the provisions in the Land Development Code regarding open spaces in residential developments. These shall include requiring that acreage equal to at least 25 percent of the buildable acreage be devoted to open space. Of this requirement, the City shall continue to require acreage equal to at least 3 percent of the buildable acreage for active recreation, but shall not require acreage equal to more than 6 percent of the building acreage for passive recreation. Of the total open space requirement, the City shall continue to require acreage equal to at least 15 percent of the buildable acreage for passive recreation.

OBJECTIVE 6.1.3: ACCESS TO RECREATION FACILITIES.

All public recreational parks and facilities shall have operational automobile, bicycle and pedestrian access as deemed appropriate by the City Commission. Accessibility shall be based upon the size, scale, facilities and programming present at the facility.

POLICY 6.1.3.1: RIGHT-OF-WAY IMPROVEMENTS.

The City shall continue to provide maintenance of recreation facility right-of-ways by qualified staff and by utilizing proper equipment. Landscaping and live plants will be properly maintained. Structures will be inspected and repaired when damage is noticed.

POLICY 6.1.3.2: DESIGN OF ACCESS FACILITIES.

All new or redeveloped public parks and facilities shall be designed and constructed with accessways that are compatible with the character and quality of on-site natural resources, and are compatible with the Americans with Disabilities Act.



POLICY 6.1.3.3: PARKING AREAS AND BICYCLE ACCOMMODATIONS.

The City shall continue to provide vehicular parking spaces and/or bicycle racks or lockers at recreational sites where needed and deemed feasible, and to meet multimodal transportation initiatives in the City.

POLICY 6.1.3.4: FACILITIES FOR HANDICAPPED AND ELDERLY.

The City shall continue to assure that future recreation areas and facilities are accessible to the disabled and the elderly.

OBJECTIVE 6.1.4: ACCESS TO LAKE TOHOPEKALIGA AND TRIBUTARIES.

The City of Kissimmee shall continue to provide and maintain access points to Lake Tohopekaliga, which serves as an entry point to portions of tributaries such as the southern part of Shingle Creek.

POLICY 6.1.4.1: REQUIRE THE AVAILABILITY AND MAINTENANCE OF BOAT RAMPS.

The City shall assure access to Lake Tohopekaliga, and Shingle Creek, by continuing to provide and maintain the existing seven boat ramps at Lakefront Park. Through an agreement with Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission, the City must keep the boat ramps and facilities open for public use, maintained in accordance with all applicable health and safety standards and kept in good repair to prevent undue deterioration and provide for public use (Paragraph 3 of Agreement #88139). Access to Shingle Creek is via Lake Tohopekaliga.

POLICY 6.1.4.2: PUBLIC ACCESS

The City will continue to actively manage Lake Tohopekaliga's natural areas to provide a safe and welcome area for the public.

OBJECTIVE 6.1.5: PUBLIC AND PRIVATE COORDINATION IN PLANNING FOR RECREATION IMPROVEMENTS.

The City shall continue to coordinate planning for recreation improvements with each level of government, including Osceola County, the Osceola County School Board, the State of Florida, community organizations, and the private sector in order to promote recreational opportunities in a cost effective manner. The City is not responsible for deficiencies in unincorporated Osceola County.

POLICY 6.1.5.1: JOINT FACILITIES USE AND PLANNING.

The City shall continue to honor the Intergovernmental Recreational Facilities Agreement with the Osceola County School Board, and all other similar interlocal agreements governing co-location and joint-use of recreation facilities. The City has amended this agreement whereby both parties agree to improve existing school recreation sites so that



these areas may also serve as neighborhood or community parks. Improvements should concentrate on adding facilities that are shown to be deficient. The City and School Board shall also jointly devise plans for developing recreational areas of future school sites to neighborhood and community park standards in accordance with the Interlocal Planning Coordination Agreement between the City and the School Board.

POLICY 6.1.5.2: CITY-COUNTY COORDINATION OF RECREATIONAL LEVELS OF SERVICE.

The City shall continue to coordinate its level of service standards for parks with those of Osceola County in close proximity to the City. Upon annexation, any deficit in park land acreage caused by the annexation shall be corrected by the City in order to meet the adopted recreation level of service standard.

POLICY 6.1.5.3: COORDINATE WITH THE PRIVATE SECTOR.

The City shall continue to coordinate with the private sector as well as existing and future businesses located within the City to develop additional mechanisms for accommodating future recreation land and facility needs.

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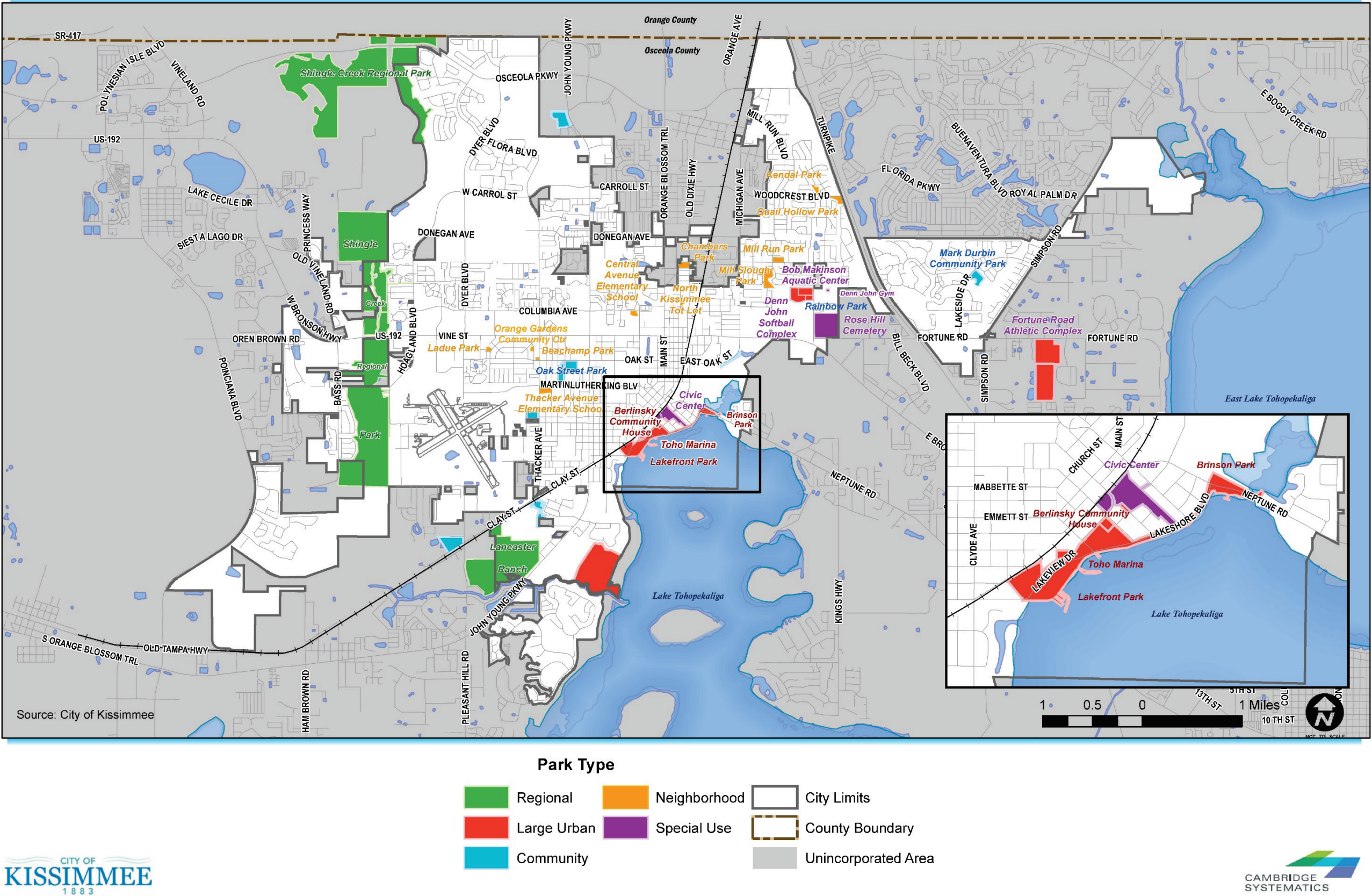
MAPS

Existing Recreation Facilities

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Figure 6-1: Existing Recreation Facilities Map



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DATA, INVENTORY, AND ANALYSIS

INTRODUCTION

This Element presents an inventory of existing recreational facilities and parks within and near the City that are accessible to the public. The bounty of natural resources in the City and surrounding area present a wealth of recreation opportunities, and the City has capitalized on that proximity to establish and maintain a number of parks that showcase these amenities. Principally among these are Shingle Creek Regional Park and Lakefront Park. Also included in the recreation inventory are other municipal and county resource-based parks, as well as sites and parks geared toward programmed activities and organized sports.

EXISTING CITY RECREATION FACILITIES

All existing public-owned recreation facilities within the City are either resource- or activity-based facilities and are classified according to size and use. In resource-based facilities, recreational activities are based on the presence of a specific natural resource, such as a lake or stream. Activities available at resource-based parks tend to be passive in nature, such as picnicking, hiking, boating, and bird watching. Activity-based facilities rely on the presence of facilities that provide sites for programmed activities and sports, such as basketball courts or soccer fields, and which may also be used for unstructured play activities. A Recreation Space Classification System was developed and the different park types within the City are classified into the categories defined below.

NEIGHBORHOOD PARK

This park type incorporates mini-parks and school parks, as well as neighborhood parks. A neighborhood park may be less than an acre in size, or up to 10 acres. It is usually within a quarter mile to a half mile distance of users' homes, uninterrupted by non-residential uses, wide roads and other physical barriers, or is located adjacent to school property.

These parks are typically developed in or near residential areas to provide public parks for specific neighborhoods. Travel to the park is usually conducted by walking or bicycling. Neighborhood parks are usually operational during daylight hours only and contain amenities such as open space, playgrounds, practice fields and picnic facilities.





COMMUNITY PARK

This park type serves a broader purpose than a neighborhood park, and the focus is on meeting community based recreational needs as well as preserving unique landscapes and open spaces. A community park is typically more than 10 acres in size, and may be up to 50 acres. It usually serves the parks and recreation needs of multiple neighborhoods and users may travel between a half mile and three miles to the park. Travel to the park is primarily conducted by walking, bicycling and motor vehicles. Community parks may typically contain an indoor recreation facility, lighted fields and courts, swimming pools and parking lots and are staffed and open to the public during evening hours.

SPECIAL USE PARK

These types are unique in nature and cover a broad range of park and recreation facilities and uses that are typically oriented towards a single purpose. They may be located on small parcels of land or may encompass a hundred acres or more, depending on the type and intensity of use. Travel to the park would typically be by motor vehicle. Users may travel longer distances and from outside the community to utilize a special use park. A special use park would contain higher intensity uses such as large public functions of an outdoor or indoor nature. Certain sports complexes, civic centers, aquatic centers, amphitheaters, and the like may be classified as special use parks.



LARGE URBAN PARK

This park type serves a broader purpose than community parks, these are used when community and neighborhood parks are not adequate to serve the needs of the community. The focus is on meeting community based park and recreational needs on a larger scale. The location of such a park is determined by the quality and suitability of the site and it usually serves the entire community. The size of a large urban park may vary but would usually contain a minimum of 20 acres, but up to 100 acres would not be uncommon. Travel to this type of park would typically be by motor vehicle but depending on its location, bicycles and pedestrians could also access the park. A large urban park could be open during evening hours and may be nature oriented or have multiple amenities that serve a particular purpose, such as boating, camping, or hiking. The only large urban park in the City is the Lakefront Park.

REGIONAL PARK

These parks provide recreational amenities to a geographic area wider than just the City and nearby areas. Typically larger than 100 acres, these parks serve multi-county areas and may be accessed by all



modes of transportation, though are typically accessed by motor vehicle. These park types may be active or passive in nature, or a combination of both. They may include athletic complexes, and nature preserves, among others.

Table 6-1 contains an inventory of parks operated and maintained by the City of Kissimmee, as well as their respective park classification. The locations of these facilities are illustrated on Figure 6-1.

Table 6-1: City of Kissimmee Inventory and Classification of Recreational Areas

Park Type	Facility	Acreage
Regional	Shingle Creek Regional Park (inside City)	460.20
	Lancaster Ranch	169.21
Large Urban	New Wetland Area Near S John Young Pkwy	96.36
	Lakefront Park / Brison Park	41.38
	Denn John Softball Complex	9.62
	Bob Makinson Aquatic Center	6.77
	Rainbow Park	2.39
	Berlins Community House	1.13
	Toho Marina	0.07
Special Use	Fortune Road Athletic Complex Southern Area	40.51
	Rose Hill Cemetery	37.82
	Fortune Road Athletic Complex	36.22
	Civic Center	13.63
	Parks & Rec Admin Office	1.99
	Denn John Gym	0.46
Community	Oak Street Park	15.16
	Area near Clay St & Thacker Ave	9.46
	Lake Side Community Park	6.97
	Area near W Emmett St & N Thacker Ave	6.00
Neighborhood	Mill Slough Park	6.65
	Thacker Avenue Elementary School	4.28
	Chambers Park	3.48
	Mill Run Park	2.50
	Quail Hollow Park	1.89
	Central Avenue Elementary School	1.28
	Kendal Park	1.15
	Ladue Park	0.71
	Orange Gardens Community Center	0.43
	Beachamp Park	0.26
	North Kissimmee Tot Lot	0.24
TOTAL		978.22
TOTAL (not including school facilities)		972.66

*The total area of Shingle Creek Regional Park is 973.18 acres. Source: City of Kissimmee, 2017.



The recreation and open space inventory above shows that the City of Kissimmee has within its borders 978 acres of publicly-owned property for recreational use, which based on its estimated 2015 population of 65,422, represents nearly 15 acres per 1,000 population. This total includes school facilities as neighborhood parks, which are available to City residents and are discussed further below. If these facilities are not included in the calculations, the City's total is 973 acres, or approximately 14.9 acres per 1,000 total residents.

An interlocal agreement was established between the School Board and the City in 1988, which has since been revised several times and described further below, to allow the City to utilize school recreational areas and facilities for general public use. The schools represent facilities that the City Parks and Recreation Department currently utilize on an ongoing basis for City-sponsored programs.

RECREATION FACILITIES MAINTAINED BY OTHER ENTITIES

The City is not the only jurisdiction to provide parks and recreational facilities to residents of the City of Kissimmee. The following entities maintain recreation sites within or near the City that may be used by City residents. These facilities are not counted toward the achievement of the City's recreation level of service standard.

OSCEOLA COUNTY RECREATION FACILITIES

In 1999, the City joined Osceola County, St. Cloud and the Osceola County School Board in recognizing that each contributes to the overall parks and recreation system within the County. The Cities of St. Cloud and Kissimmee offer comprehensive parks and recreation programs, and are responsible for providing a majority of active recreation opportunities to City and County residents, as well as residents in nearby Orange County. Osceola County, on the other hand, tends to provide mostly passive parks, boat ramps and special use parks such as the County's Softball Complex, and many of these are outside the City's boundary. The County also has a significant amount of undeveloped park lands that will eventually be open to the public for active and passive recreational uses. As the area grows and becomes increasingly urban, the county-wide system is under great pressure to provide additional program capacity, upgraded facilities and new parks and recreation facilities.



PUBLIC SCHOOL SITE RECREATION FACILITIES

An official agreement exists between the Osceola County School Board and the City of Kissimmee to allow the City to use school “property and any facilities constructed thereon” for recreational purposes, including playgrounds and athletic facilities at area schools. The *Master Joint Use and Development of Recreational Facilities* agreement was signed in May 1988, revised in 1997, 2003, and most recently in 2008, and outlines use and maintenance responsibilities. Co-location and the joint-use of facilities was also incorporated into the 2003 interlocal agreement for the coordination of public school facilities planning, and the 2009 agreement relating to school concurrency and the planning and coordination of public school facilities. School facilities are only available when the property is not being used for school purposes, however.



STATE AND FEDERAL RECREATION FACILITIES

Prairie Lake State Preserve, Three Lakes Wildlife Management Area, and Bull Creek Wildlife Management Area are managed by the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission. They are all located in close proximity to each other, and approximately 8 miles north of Kenansville on SR 523. The three parks provide picnic areas, a boat ramp, hunting and fishing areas and hiking and biking trails.

PRIVATE RECREATION FACILITIES

A vast number of private recreational facilities within or near Kissimmee are available to the public. The City is within a twenty mile drive of several large, nationally recognized recreation attractions and amusement parks including Disney World Resort, Sea World of Orlando, and Universal Studios. A number of smaller commercial recreational facilities are also located within or adjacent to Kissimmee, including golf courses, batting cages, and putt-putt golf courses.

Additionally, many private single family and multi-family housing developments provide much of the recreational opportunities for the City’s residents. Facilities include swimming pools, tot lots, tennis courts, open spaces, trails and the like.

CURRENT RECREATION DEMANDS AND NEEDS

The quality of recreation cannot be judged solely on the amount of land area dedicated to and developed for recreational uses, but invariably must consider the facilities provided, as well as the desires of the community. In general, facilities located in City parks enable residents to participate in both active and



passive recreation activities. A variety of facilities and park types are available to service the recreation needs for a diverse range of interests and age groups, including soccer fields, baseball and softball fields, basketball and tennis courts, and swimming pools.

The City of Kissimmee has determined that parks should be designed to provide service to both active and passive recreation needs, and be composed of parks of varying size in order to serve neighborhoods, communities, and the City as a whole. The City provides five basic park types, neighborhood parks, community parks, special use facilities, regional parks, and large urban parks. School facilities were not included in the needs analysis.

Rather than establish a level of service (LOS) for each park type, the City has adopted an overall per capita LOS of five acres per 1,000 population. Based on this minimum standard, the City's estimated 2015 population of 65,422 would require 327.11 acres of recreational space to fulfill the recreation land demands. The City currently has a total of 972.66 acres of non-school recreation facilities, which is over 600 acres more than the population would demand, based on the five acre per 1,000 standard. With the projected population of 92,445 in 2045, the City will still meet the minimum standard with more than ten acres per 1,000 people.

The Shingle Creek regional park actually contains 973.18 acres, but some of the land is within unincorporated Osceola County. The facility is managed jointly by the County and the City to allow resource-based recreational use, but is currently not included in the City's LOS calculations. It should be noted, however, that the likelihood exists that this facility will be wholly within the City before the end of the planning period.



DISTRIBUTION OF RECREATIONAL SPACE

Although some recreational spaces are located in the northwest sector, that portion of the City presently lacks facilities to best meet the needs of nearby residents. Facilities are primarily comprised of special use parks and undeveloped open space, with school facilities that can provide additional recreational opportunities. Facilities at Kissimmee Elementary School adjacent to the existing Kissimmee Middle provide an opportunity for co-location of recreation facilities for nearby residents. This area is also served by the Kissimmee Trail that provides nearby residents access to schools and nearby Shingle Creek.

Special Use parks are in high demand and provide additional opportunities to provide residents with needed active recreational facilities such as pools, ball fields and football/soccer fields. By involving the



public, the City can determine what specific facilities are needed when parks are developed or expanded in the future.

A minimum amount of area (five acres per 1,000 population) is required to satisfy level of service requirements that support the park types residents demand. Table 6-3 shows the percentage breakdown of park acreage by type, and does not include school facilities listed as neighborhood parks in Table 6-1.

Table 6-2: Park Classification and Percentage Distribution

Park Type	Acres	Percent of Total
Regional	629.41	64%
Large Urban	157.72	16%
Special Use	130.64	13%
Community	37.59	4%
Neighborhood	22.86	2%
Total	978.22	100%

Source: City of Kissimmee, 2017.

According to the above table, the City contains almost two thirds of its recreation land in the Regional Park type of facility, namely Shingle Creek and Lancaster Ranch. The highest priority facility needs include trails, bikeways and sidewalks, miles of which have been constructed, and which will continue to be added to the City's recreation and transportation systems. In its parks, the City has also worked to enhance indoor recreational facilities, play and practice fields and youth sports and school parks to continue to meet the needs of underserved areas in the community. Adding cultural opportunities, such as amphitheaters or public art, will provide additional opportunities to enhance the outdoor and recreation experience for residents and visitors.

VISITOR RECREATION DEMANDS

Thousands of tourists and visitors come to Osceola County and the City of Kissimmee every week. Many are attracted to the area by large amusement and theme parks located in or near the County. Although most tourists visiting Kissimmee for more than a day find shelter in motels, short-term rental residences or stay with friends or relatives, some stay at one of the three privately-owned campgrounds located within the City limits. The City does not maintain any public campground facilities at any of its parks. Like other tourists visiting the areas, campers are primarily here to visit one or more of the nearby major amusement parks or theme parks. With the number of campsites





available provided by the privately operated campgrounds near Kissimmee, the City does not anticipate a need to provide any public campground sites in its parks.

Only small portions of these visitors utilize municipal parks and recreational facilities while staying in the City. Those most likely to use City's park are boaters, angler and campers, who actively take advantage of the recreational resources Lake Tohopekaliga and other nearby lakes have to offer. Based on current availability of boat ramps, fishing piers and lakefront parks along Lake Tohopekaliga, the City provides adequate facilities to meet the boating and fishing needs of both its residents and guests.

ALL INCLUSIVE RECREATION

The provision of recreational facilities should consider needs of people of all abilities, including the elderly, disabled, and young adolescents. Parks and recreational facilities should be designed to accommodate special access needs of both senior citizens and disabled persons. Neighborhood, community, and regional parks and special use facilities should include handicapped parking spaces for the mobility-impaired, while recreation facilities such as fishing piers, pavilions and ball field



stadiums should contain ramp structures at entrance points to permit access and eventual participation. Without special design considerations at access points, many disabled persons and senior citizens may not be able to participate in active or passive recreation activities.

FUTURE RECREATION NEEDS

Future growth in resident population and in tourism within the City of Kissimmee will create a need for additional recreational space and facilities. Increased recreation needs, though, will largely be attributed to future residents, while tourists and visitors will only place a minimal impact on public recreation space and facilities. The future needs of each population group are further analyzed below.

Table 6-4 describes the projected demand for recreational space through the year 2045. The project demand estimates were derived by comparing future populations projections with current available recreation acreage. Determination of future recreational facility demands is based on the existing standard of 5 acres per 1,000 persons. The recreation facilities the City provides are the only ones used to calculate achievement of LOS standards. Joint-ventures between the City and the County are not included in the calculations, but as noted earlier, both the School District and the County's parks contribute toward the park space available for residents of Kissimmee. The table below indicates that the City will maintain its adopted LOS through the planning period in 2045. It should be noted that if the



two large regional parks are excluded from the calculation, the remaining recreation land consists of approximately 349 acres. With the exclusion, the 2015 LOS is 5.3 acres per 1,000 persons and the projected LOS in 2045 falls to 3.8 acres per 1,000 persons.

Table 6-3: Projected Recreation Facility Needs

Year	City Population Projection	Acres Needed*	Actual LOS (acres per 1,000)
2015	65,422	327.11	14.95
2020	74,560	372.80	13.12
2025	82,688	413.44	11.83
2030	88,416	442.08	11.06
2035	91,392	456.96	10.70
2040	92,416	462.08	10.58
2045	92,445	462.23	10.58

**Based on projected population and adopted LOS of 5 acres per 1,000 population.*

Future recreation demands created by tourists and visitors will primarily be met by privately-owned recreational facilities. Only a minimal demand for public recreation will be created by future tourists and visitors, most of who will come to the area to visit major theme and amusement parks. Boating and fishing opportunities found within Lake Tohopekaliga will continue to attract anglers and boaters to the lakefront area, which will undergo redevelopment during the planning period.

DEVELOPMENT OF NEW PARKS

Although the City (when all acreage of the Shingle Creek Regional Park is included) has a large surplus of recreation acreage relative to the demand that will be created by 2045, additional parks will needed in neighborhoods that lack close access to neighborhood and community parks, to maintain an equitable distribution of recreation facilities, and to keep pace with future recreational space and facility demands.

Extension and development of new and existing trails, bikeways and sidewalks will increase access between neighborhoods and public spaces, which effectively increases the service area of smaller park types. These parks and facilities should be designed to serve those specific areas and provide facilities according to the needs of residents of the surrounding areas.

The least expensive and most expedient means of augmenting recreation services include:

1. Providing additional facilities at existing developed parks, thereby expanding their service areas as well as the population they will serve;
2. Upgrading and improving open spaces to serve a more intensive recreational function where consistent with conservation objectives.



Additionally, large private developments may need to dedicate public park lands to the City in order to meet the demand in particular areas of the City. As noted above, the City has an abundance of regional park facilities and open spaces, which are geared primarily to preservation and passive recreation. In the future the City will consider increasing the percentage of acres devoted to neighborhood, community and special use parks. Providing new types of parks also will be provided or explored as community preferences change with time, such as dog parks, splash parks, skate parks, plazas in urban areas, and unforeseen opportunities.



USE OF SCHOOL RECREATION SITES

The use of school recreation sites for public recreation purposes represents an efficient use of these facilities and of public tax expenditures. Once students leave school grounds after daily classes end, recreational facilities are left unused when not made available to the public. School recreation facilities are available for public use through the Interlocal Agreements between the City, the County, the City of St. Cloud, and the Osceola County School Board, which specifically include a section on co-location of public schools and public recreation facilities. At times, however, these existing school facilities must be augmented and improved before they will adequately meet recreational needs of the general public.

The City of Kissimmee and the School District will continue to coordinate all future development plans so decisions on future school site locations can incorporate both educational and recreational needs of the City's residents. Similarly, the locations of parks near schools also compliment the athletic and recreation activities available to students. Since school recreation sites will generally serve areas identical to their education service areas, school facilities should be utilized for the following recreational purposes:

- Elementary School facilities as Neighborhood Parks
- Middle School facilities as Neighborhood or Community Parks
- High School facilities as Neighborhood, Community or Special Use Parks

Recreational facilities located within these school types should comply with Department of Education guidelines, and the City shall coordinate with the School District to ensure the facilities will also meet City standards for the above recreational classification.



COORDINATION WITH CONSERVATION AREAS AND NATURAL RESOURCES

In addition to their recreational purposes, parks located between natural resource protection areas and urban development often serve to protect the health and safety of residents by preventing natural or man-induced hazards from entering populated areas. As open space, parks can serve as buffers between incompatible land uses, such as industrial and residential uses. Their presence can also prevent development from intruding into, and detrimentally affecting, environmentally sensitive areas, such as wetlands and certain vegetative communities. Future recreational spaces may best be located along or within natural resource areas, where they can serve both recreational and conservation functions. A number of Kissimmee's parks are already located adjacent to natural resources.

Natural waterways and canals, and stormwater management areas, represent ideal locations to develop linear parks and open space corridors, as well as pedestrian and bicycle pathways that can enhance and diversify the City's transportation network. With park locations already bordering these corridors, the City can continue to develop an inter-connected park system that traverses through several residential neighborhoods.

DISTRIBUTION OF FUTURE RECREATIONAL FACILITIES

Recreational space, particularly neighborhood and community parks, should be located in areas accessible to Kissimmee's population. Current recreational space may meet the adopted LOS for total area, but existing parks may not necessarily be located in areas of current and future residential growth. Many parks are located south of Vine Street, but new development is most likely to the northwest and northeast portions of the City. Additionally, redevelopment opportunities are primarily located in the central area of the City. Future recreational spaces will need to be located in areas where growth and development are anticipated to occur.

The City of Kissimmee should continue to coordinate its future recreation plans with the County and School District to avoid duplication of services provided by both entities. The City of Kissimmee should also encourage the County to implement the proposed parks and recreation system outlined in the County Master Plan, which is in the process of being updated for the new decade. The City will also continue to require private developers to supply parks and recreational facilities as part of development projects with residential uses, according to the Land Development Code.

SUMMARY

The City will continue to provide parks and recreational facilities to existing and projected residents, and will do so by taking into account residents' recreational preferences, geographic concentrations, and land available for recreation sites. In order to provide additional facilities, the City may require the dedication of public recreation facilities as part of large private development projects. Additionally, as the City annexes land, recreation facilities may come to be located within the City boundary. This will increase the quantity of recreation lands with the City, and raise the actual LOS above the minimum required standard.